ISSUE 4

GALLIONS grapevine

April 2001

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION



New arrival

We are delighted to introduce a new arrival at the Association in the form of Fred Angole, our new Finance Director.

Fred joins us from Presentation Housing Association in South West London where he spent 5 years as Director of Operations. Previous to this Fred also spent 4 years working for the Housing Corporation.

Fred begins working with us in June.



New Customer Services Manager

Sharon McGregor joined us in March this year from LB Lewisham where she was Operations Manager for the Housing office. Sharon has over 16 years of housing management experience, working in such areas as income collection, rehousing, tenancy matters, reception service, area regeneration and customer interface.

Both these appointments are part of Gallions Housing Association's plans to make our services the best.

Investing in better customer services



In response to growing demand and as part of our commitment to do all that we can to provide the very best in customer services, we are pleased to announce the opening of our new Customer Service Centre at our offices in Harrow Manor Way.

Our aim over the coming months is to develop the Service Centre so that we provide a complete 'one-stop, walk-in' housing service to all of our customers. It will take us a little time to achieve this and we want your views and suggestions about the services we should provide.

Tell us what you want us to do. What sort of services do you think we should offer? How about letting us know when you want the Service Centre to be open? We can't provide a twenty-four hour service but perhaps there are times that would suit better?

As part of our ongoing customer services policy, we will be conducting a survey shortly. Please take the time to help by giving us your views and having a say in shaping our services.

Commenting on the new Customer Services Centre Tony Cotter, Chief Executive said:

"At Gallions Housing Association we intend to deliver the highest standards of customer services. We are listening to the views of our customers and then taking action. The new Customer Service Centre is a direct result of this and other additions to our services, for example improving the way we handle telephone enquiries, are now also planned.

It is important that we succeed with such initiatives and that our customers see improvements. We will therefore continue to encourage our customers to talk to us and tell us their views. I am very pleased to be able to announce the opening of the new Customer Service Centre and both I and all of the staff at Gallions Housing Association will be working hard to make it a success."

The Service Centre is open for business now and our staff will do all they can to help you 'across the counter'. Perhaps you would like some privacy when you come in? No problem! Just ask one of the Service Centre staff and we'll happily talk to you in the privacy of a meeting room.

You can walk-in at any time during opening hours and we will help with any housing-related matter, from arranging a repair to advising you about your right to buy your property. We aim to provide an open, friendly and welcoming service to all of our customers with as little waiting time as possible, so pay us a visit and let us know what you think.

CUSTOMER SERVICE CENTRE OPENING TIMES:

Mon – Fri	09:00 to 17:00
(Late night opening on Wednesday to 20:00)	
Saturdays	10:00 – 13:00

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Can't pay or won't pay?

Getting the money that we are owed is vital if we are to deliver the services that our customers need. As a 'not-for-profit' organisation the money that we earn from our rents is our lifeblood.

At Gallions Housing Association we are launching a renewed campaign on all debt and a much more rigorous approach towards the collection of rents and other charges. However, we do realise that we all encounter financial difficulties from time to time so we will also be setting up debt advisory and information services during the course of the next financial year.

To begin with, we are targeting those accounts with very large debts. Any account holders who refuse to pay their service-charges will be taken to court to protect the interest of the Association and of all other residents.

Whether it is existing tenants, former tenants or service charge payers who owe us money, we will seek to enforce our rights as a landlord so that customers who pay on-time are not affected by those who do not. None of us like being short-changed, it's not fair and we recognise that often it is those customers who stick by their agreements with us who could suffer as a result of increasing numbers of people who do not pay their bills.

We want to keep rents affordable, improve our services and enhance standards. To do this we need people to pay their bills to us on time. We now have a team specifically focussed on managing our revenue and, where people run into problems, they can agree alternative terms that may be more manageable.

Our aim is to be firm, fair and flexible. At the end of the day though, we can't survive as a 'not-for-profit' organisation without the money coming in. So, if you are one of our customers who may be unable to pay your rent – whatever the reason – then come in and talk to us so that we can work something out for you. You do not need to make an appointment. Ask to speak to a member of the Income Protection team or telephone us – the number is on the back of this copy of Grapevine. It is better for you to talk to us because we want to help you. If we can't help we may be able to put you in touch with people who can.

If you are a tenant remember;

Losing your home can be avoided but if you do choose to ignore bills and subsequent reminders then we will enforce our rights under our agreements. If you receive Housing Benefit remember also that it is your responsibility to ensure that it is paid. Avoid getting into difficulties by talking to us!

Deep Cleaning Contract

A positive 90% YES was recorded in February when over 600 residents responded to a consultation questionnaire to deep clean areas of Thamesmead.

Gallions Housing Association already has strict guidelines in place when cleaning Thamesmead, but Marshes EMB1 (Broadwaters, Waterfield and Moorings) wanted to invest in an additional thorough, one-off, deep clean. A bidding process was conducted on the 5th March which resulted in one of the contractors being chosen and work has already begun this month. *EMB 1 would like to thank all those who responded.*



A Cleaner Thamesmead



A major new initiative is underway to improve the environment in Thamesmead. Gallions is attempting to brighten up the area by installing new rubbish bins in the parks and public open spaces.

A big effort is being made to encourage residents and visitors to become more conscious about their neighbourhoods. In particular, the Board will be working closely with all residents to encourage people to take their rubbish home with them, use the rubbish bins where possible and avoid dumping rubbish all over Thamesmead. There is also a great deal of concern about children playing in open spaces and being at risk because dogs are being allowed to foul the grass areas. We appeal to dog owners to please clean up after their dog.

We all have a responsibility to improve the quality of life for our residents.

What we need is your help.

See back page for your list of contacts

New EMB Initiatives

For more information contact EMB area 1. 2 or 3, Tenant Resource Cen
Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Manor Way Green Play Area

Tump 47 EMB 2



Planning permission for this project has now been granted and drawings and plans are reaching final stages.

After soil testing for safety purposes takes place, construction will start and the work will take about 8 weeks to complete.

This is a £200,000 project, so contact us with your positive ideas. We need residents to join the Park User Groups and welcome input from both young and old.

Limestone Walk Project

EMB 3



The continuing revitalisation of Limestone Walk is a priority as part of plans for the new EMB budget.

Attractive murals will be erected, designed and created by our local young people.

Ideas are underway to modernise the Limestone Club and again your ideas are welcomed.

Thamesmead Property Marking

Selectamark area – EMB 1



Thamesmead Property Marking Partnership (Broadwaters, Waterfield and Moorings) Area 1 Marshes in partnership with the Metropolitan Police are piloting a scheme to reduce crime in Thamesmead.

The project began on the 12th March this year and is making good progress. This has been part funded by EMB 1, and offers you FREE permanent visible property marking.

Stencils containing postcodes have already been produced and the police officers will even mark the property for you.

REMEMBER, marked property has little value to a burglar, and has reduced burglary by up to 96% in some areas.

The Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Community Safety Partnership

Working together for a safer community

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Trust Thamesmead

Tilfen

Greenwich Council

Greenwich Community Safety Trust

METROPOLITAN POLICE

BEXLEY COUNCIL

Abbey Wood Thamesmead Partnership

A project to make Abbey Wood and Thamesmead a safer place for all has taken a big step forward recently.

Gallions Housing Association has confirmed that it is to fund a new post of Project Manager for a minimum of two years

The new Project Manager, Andrea Kilvington, began working with the Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Community Safety Partnership Project on April 9. Andrea has extensive research and consultancy experience in crime-related issues from working with the Home Office and other agencies. Although funded by Gallions Housing Association Andrea is employed by the Greenwich Community Safety Trust. When asked about her new role, she said "I very much look forward to working with the community, towards the development of innovative community safety initiatives which directly reflect local needs."

John Fahy, chair of Gallions Housing Association, says: "Thamesmead is a great place to be and our task is to help make it even better and safer for our residents."

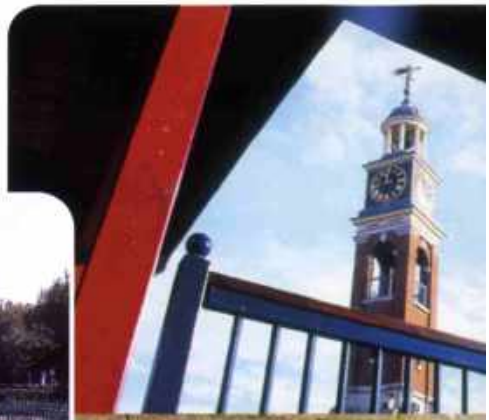
The Project for a safer community is being planned by the Abbey Wood and Thamesmead Community Safety Partnership. Led by Gallions Housing Association, it includes a range of local organisations, the Metropolitan Police and Bexley and Greenwich councils.

Begun in October last year, the Project has been looking at local crime hotspots and statistics. This information will help it draw up a tough plan to tackle crime and the causes of crime. Much of the emphasis is on how all groups in the community can work together to deal effectively with these issues that affect everyone's lives.

Some of the new initiatives already launched:

- **Motor Vehicle Crime Initiative**
- **Racially Motivated Crime Project**
- **Youth Awareness Programme**
- **Equipment Marking Scheme**
- **Supporting Victim Support**







Swipe card rent payment now introduced



For many years our customers have been able to come to the Association offices in Harrow manor Way and make rent payments by cash or cheque at the hand till machine.

We want to reduce the costly burden this work places upon us and also reduce the security risk of having large amounts of cash on our premises. We also want to provide a more flexible way for our customers to pay rents.

In common with many other organisations we have therefore introduced payment swipe cards. For each type of rent account we have issued a swipe card to all customers. The swipe card, together with payment, can then be handed over at any Post Office or at a shop showing the Paypoint sign.

Customers will receive a receipt for the deposits made. It couldn't be simpler.

For more information or to talk to somebody about the new swipe card, please call us on **0208 310 1500** and ask for the **Customer First Team** or email us at **CustomerFirst@gallionsha.co.uk**

Revised Terms and Condition Tenancy Agreement

Prizewinners

Five lucky winners received over £1,500 worth of Sainsbury vouchers as a result of completing their revised tenancy agreements.

Sharon McGregor, our new customer services manager, was delighted to present some of the prizewinners with their vouchers on the 23rd March.





Pictured above with Sharon is Mrs Olarinmaye and her daughter.

Pictured left are Ms J Bertie, Mr and Mrs Burgess and Sharon.

Congratulations to all the prizewinners from Gallions Housing Association

Just for fun

wordsearch

Can you find the names of ten items you might find in a garden shed? The names can be found across, down, up or diagonally in either direction:

Q	L	A	W	N	M	O	W	E	R	E	C
T	T	F	M	M	R	D	O	A	N	S	J
L	G	N	Q	O	S	M	K	H	L	T	O
X	Z	P	V	G	N	E	X	O	S	H	P
L	T	P	P	Q	E	N	E	E	Y	A	Y
W	V	M	X	N	U	I	P	D	W	A	P
I	B	V	N	H	R	W	T	A	S	D	N
E	Y	U	F	C	X	T	W	P	W	B	P
A	T	T	C	O	M	P	O	S	T	N	L
S	S	T	I	K	R	E	Y	G	O	C	N
C	L	V	H	G	E	K	A	R	Q	I	X
A	M	S	E	C	A	T	E	U	R	S	O

Coming soon ...

Gallions Housing Association Board elections

Over the next few months the Board elections for Gallions Housing Association will be taking place.

You will receive election details on each of the candidates.

This is your chance to have your say on who you wish to represent tenants and charge-payers on the Board of Gallions Housing Association.

For further details please contact Caroline Wilson, Gallions Housing Association on **020 8320 3409**.

24-hour benefit fraud hotline launched

Bexley Council has launched a 24-hour telephone hotline in its latest bid to combat Housing and Council Tax fraud.

The hotline number is 020 8308 4948 and an answering machine is in operation outside office hours.

Callers ringing the hotline can leave details of those they think are trying to cheat the system. Information received will be checked against benefit records and may lead to prosecution.

The number and complexity of cases reaching the courts is unprecedented and has resulted in a large number of prosecutions.

Contacts

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

Main Switchboard
(for housing and other enquiries)
020 8310 1500

Repairs Freephone
0800 838481

Comfort 2000 Heating
020 8320 3422

Interserve
0800 389 0154